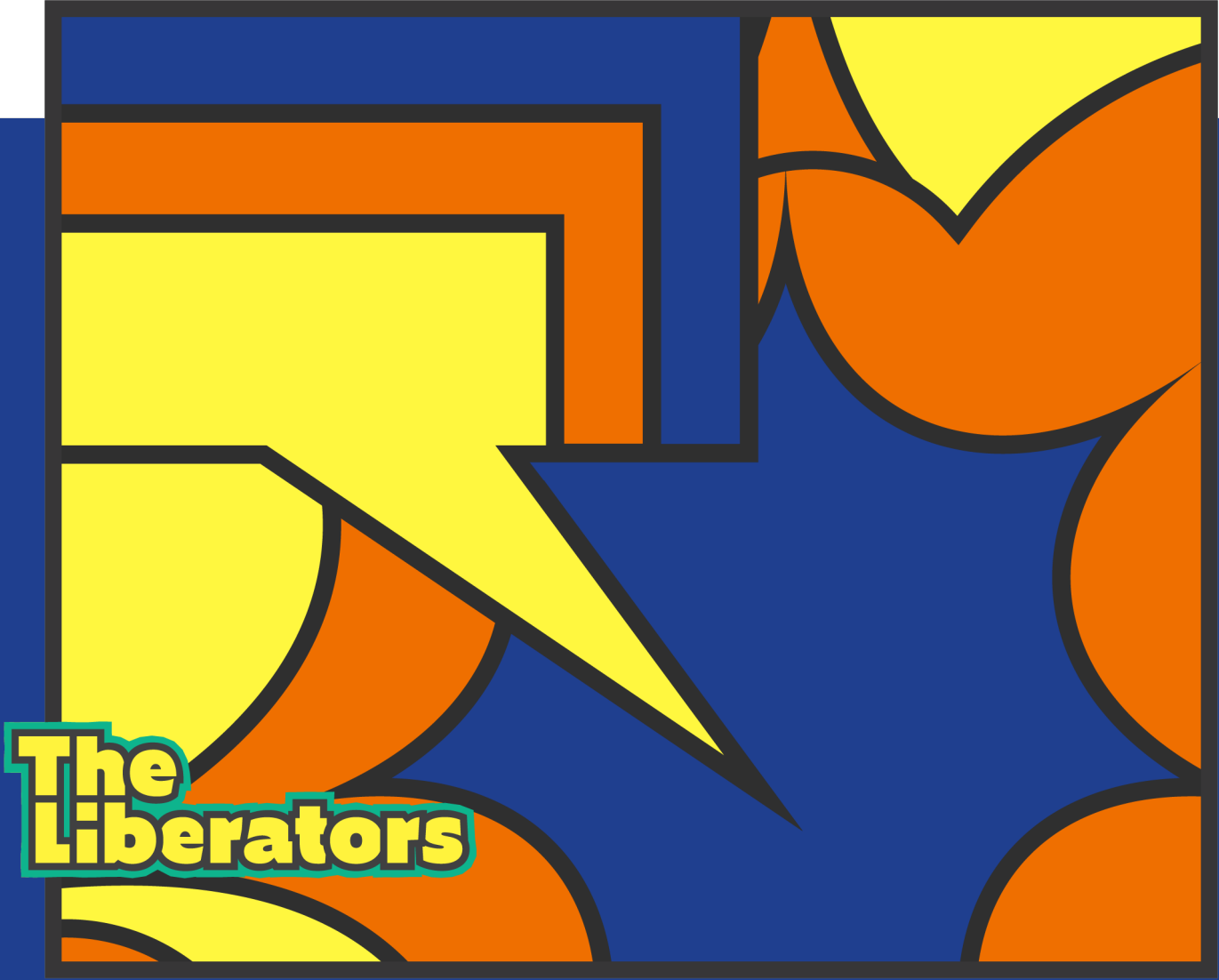


Narrow Down A Feature To Its Essentials In Order To Ship Faster

A do-it-yourself workshop to narrow down and refine the work needed for a potential feature to the absolute essential "Walking Skeleton", with "Min Specs"

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large yellow rectangle, a yellow triangle pointing downwards, and several orange and yellow curved shapes. The text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a black outline and a blue drop shadow, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Scrum teams and organizations often understand why it is important to release frequently, or "ship fast" as we call it in our [book](#). But knowing that it is important and actually doing it are different things.

One of the areas where this tension is quite evident is in the struggle between "the best way to implement a feature" and the "fastest way to implement a feature". Or "the simplest version of the product" and the "best possible version of the product". Many Scrum teams get stuck in a vicious cycle where they keep adding more features, bells, and whistles before a new release is acceptable. But each cycle increases the risk that the team is potentially wasting their efforts on unwanted or unnecessary additions.

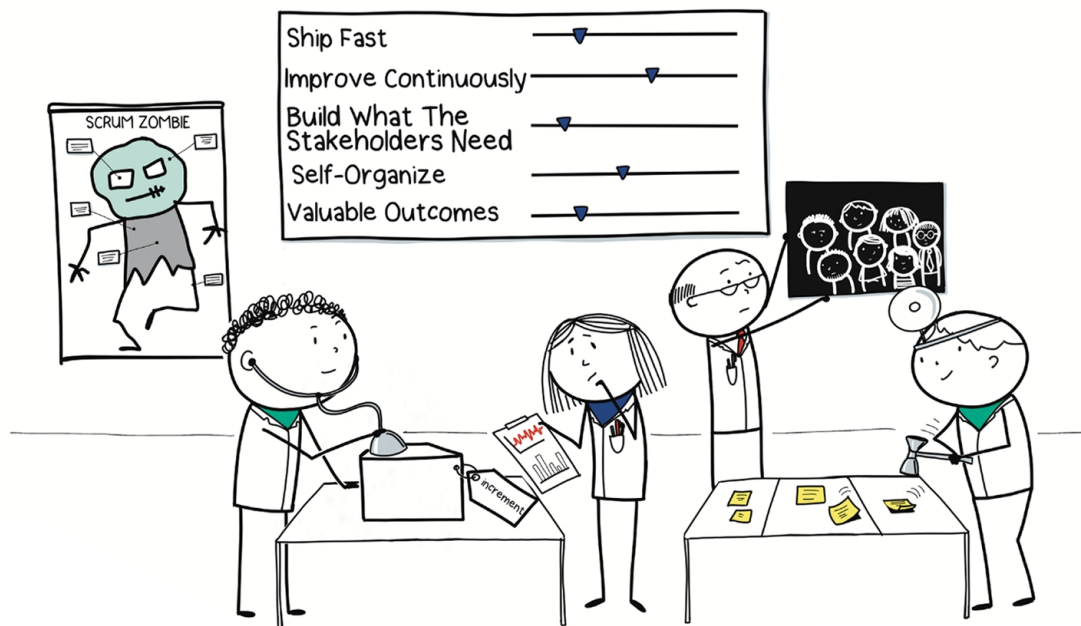
The ability to ship fast depends a great deal on your creativity as a team to find the simplest possible way to implement and release a feature, or even an entire product, while maintaining high quality.

We designed this workshop for teams that are struggling to break down a large feature, or even an entire product, into smaller items that can be delivered to stakeholders individually. You can use it either at the start of development for a new product or during development.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Feature With "Celebrity Interview"

  25 min

Step 3: Narrow Down What Is Needed With "Min Specs"

  45 min

Step 4: Narrow Down Even Further With "Impromptu Networking"

  20 min

Step 5: Personal Next Steps

  5 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 100 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



We designed this workshop to be as easy to facilitate as possible.

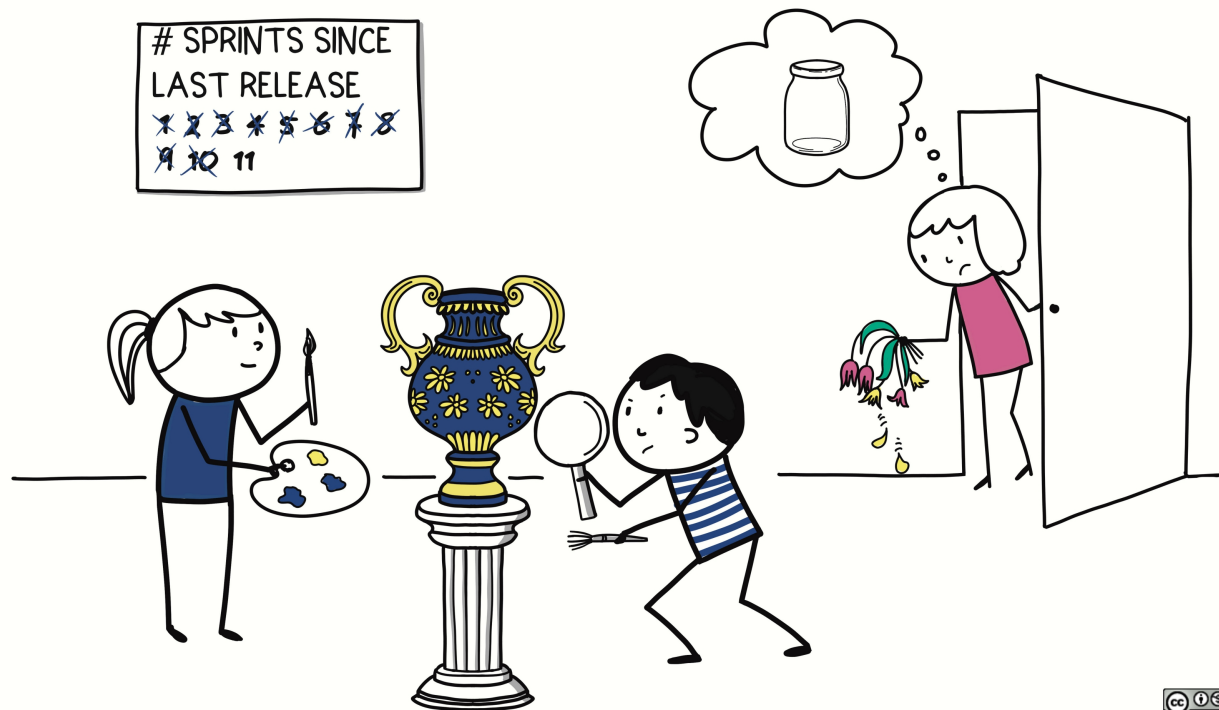
Impact On Survival



Once teams start to get it and develop strategies to keep things simple, it becomes easier to ship faster.



About Walking Skeletons



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Venwije, Johannes Schürten & Barry Overseem
zombiescrum.org

Scrum teams are often tempted to implement the best possible, most robust, and most polished version of a product feature. While the intentions behind that are noble, it also introduces significant risk. Because every hour and every day that you spend on the same unreleased feature is another day that is potentially wasted if the feature turns out to be unnecessary, unneeded, or quite different from what users expected.

When the coin drops that time is potentially wasted, the question becomes: "What is the simplest way for us to implement and test a feature with users before layering on more?"

A Walking Skeleton

A common metaphor among Agile teams is to think about products, and individual features, in terms of "Walking Skeletons". The term was initially coined by [Alistair Cockburn](#), and defined as:

"A Walking Skeleton is a tiny implementation of the system that performs a small end-to-end function. It need not use the final architecture, but it should link together the main architectural components. The architecture and the functionality can then evolve in parallel"

While the concept was initially applied to entire systems or products, we've found the thinking particularly helpful for individual features as well. The goal here is to remove everything that isn't essential and to start with that and see how it works with real users and in the real world. This allows you to learn – empirically – what else is helpful for users, and you can then layer this on with your team.



It is clear that this approach capitalizes on the incremental and iterative nature of Agile approaches. You don't have to get the feature completely right the first time. If you release a "walking skeleton" in the first iteration, you can make important adjustments and release new versions in the next iterations. But everything you add can then be grounded in the experience and needs of your users, rather than what you assume their experience and needs are.

High-Quality Skeletons

Because "Walking Skeletons" are likely to evolve over time, it is important to realize that your team needs to channel all its professionalism to balance the need for getting something out quickly with the need for high-quality code. In a good "Walking Skeleton", the code is just as production-ready as a "finished product". A "Walking Skeleton" is not a prototype or a proof-of-concept, but working, testable and shippable code. At the same time, it is important to recognize that teams can also get lost in endless refactoring to get perfect code. Here too, teams have to learn what to optimize now and what to optimize later.

Some Examples

- For the [Scrum Team Survey](#) we wanted to implement a subscription model to enable premium features for users. But the actual implementation of such a model in the app introduced a lot of potential work (e.g. invoicing, payment, refunds), against the potential risk that no users would be interested in such a model. So we began with a "Walking Skeleton" where users can purchase a code in our existing [webshop](#) to unlock premium features. Our webshop already offered a secure platform for online purchases and already generated valid invoices. So we could now focus our efforts on the unlocking of features with a code. This slashed development time from several weeks to only two days. Although the "Walking Skeleton" wasn't as integrated and user-friendly as a fully integrated subscription model, it at least allowed us to test our hypothesis against minimal efforts.
- A Scrum team we once worked with was tasked with the development of time registration software where temp workers would track their hours, managers would check those hours and HR employees would pay money for time worked. Although each of these steps needed to be automated at some point, we focused the "Walking Skeleton" on the time entries by temp workers. We identified the most common entry scenarios and implemented those in the first Sprints. For other, unsupported scenarios, we pointed temp workers to the existing (manual) process. And instead of adding a full UI for checks by management and HR employees in the first iterations, we instead exported the hours in Excel (a UI that everyone was already highly familiar with). The first version of the product was released after two weeks and iterated over time to include all the other desired features.

It Is All About Refinement

The definition of a Walking Skeleton is by definition an act of refinement. Whenever you tackle a new product or a new feature, it helps to think about: "What is the riskiest part?", "What can we do manually if we need to?" and "What delivers value before anything else?". These kinds of questions help you both in breaking down larger items of work, but also to order them in terms of what is the most valuable for your stakeholders. So these are valuable skills to master!

Resources

- Blogpost: [The New User Story Backlog is a Map](#)
- Blogpost: [5 Questions To Ask Yourself Before Writing Code](#)



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that is tackling individual features. But the steps also work really well with more Scrum teams and an entire product as its focus.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- If you like, prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Ship Fast](#)



3 min

Step 1: Opening



Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of The Feature With "Celebrity Interview"



This workshop is all about narrowing down a potential feature to the "smallest possible implementation" that still meets the Definition of Done. In order to make this work, it is important for the team to understand the purpose of the feature, so that it can act as the touchstone to decide on what to do now and what to do later – or not at all.

This is a good opportunity for the Product Owner to help the team understand the "Why?" behind a feature. We're using a short variation of the Liberating Structure [Celebrity Interview](#) to give the Product Owner and opportunity to do so, and for the team to ask urgent questions.

Steps

1. **5 min** Invite the Product Owner to take 5 minutes (no more) of uninterrupted time to explain the purpose of the feature. Why is it important? What should it make possible for users? What would need to happen to conclude that the feature is a smashing success? The team doesn't interrupt.
2. **10 min** When the Product Owner is done, give the other members a minute of silent thinking to write down one or two questions they have **1 min**, and then form pairs to refine and write down their two most important questions **3 min**. If you do this virtually, you can briefly move pairs into breakouts for a few minutes. When everyone is back together, collect the questions on a shared workspace **4 min**.
3. **10 min** Invite the Product Owner to again take 10 minutes (no more) of uninterrupted time to answer the questions in whatever order makes sense to them.

Our Findings

- The name for "Celebrity Interview" sometimes puts people off. But Keith McCandless – one of the founders of Liberating Structures – always emphasizes that the name is quite purposeful. The "celebrity" gets a podium to share their view, while also receiving tough and difficult questions to sharpen and (potentially) sharpen that view.
- We recommend that you tightly facilitate this structure, including the uninterrupted timeboxes for the Product Owner, when your team has the habit of going on and on or interrupting each other. The purpose here is to get the most burning questions answered quickly, and not to work out everything in detail.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Celebrity Interview: Reconnect the Experience of Leaders and Experts with People Closest to the Challenge at Hand](#)

Step 3: Narrow Down What Is Needed With "Min Specs"



Now that the team has a good understanding of the purpose of the feature, it is time to identify the work that is needed to implement that feature. Many teams initially struggle to narrow down and limit to what is absolutely essential and instead add more and more work to a feature. We're using the Liberating Structure [Min Specs](#) to give teams a clear structure to first think broadly, and then to narrow down with the purpose in mind.

Invitations

Step #2: "In silence, tell the story of what the implementation and release of this feature would look like in your team. What would happen first, what would be needed then? Write down all the steps, changes, decisions, and checks that are part of the story."

Step #4: "Carefully go through the 'Max Specs' and test each item against the purpose we have for this feature and our Definition of Done. If we can still achieve the purpose when we decide to do this item later or not at all, remove it from the list."

Steps

1. **2 min** For the feature that you'd like to focus on, ask everyone to write down a list of the changes and modifications that are necessary to successfully implement this feature and release it to stakeholders.
2. **10 min** Invite people into small groups (2-4) or move them into breakouts if you're doing this virtually. Ask people to combine and expand their lists in their small groups with the invitation for Step 2.
3. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask each group to share their list on a whiteboard or a virtual workspace and work together to combine it into one list for the whole group (these are the "Max Specs"). Remove duplicates as you go, but avoid lengthy discussions and technical decisions.
4. **10 min** Ask the Product Owner to re-iterate the purpose of this feature. Then, invite people back into their small groups (2-4), or move them into breakouts if you're doing this virtually. Ask the small groups with the invitation for Step 4 to test each item in the "Max Specs" against the purpose statement.

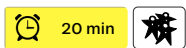
5. **10 min** When everyone is back together, or back in the main channel, ask the groups to share which items they removed, and work together to remove those items from your shared "Max Specs" list. The resulting list is your "Min Specs".

Our Findings

- When your team really struggles to remove items from the "Max Specs", you can do another fifth round, but with new groups.
- A print of this poster with [10 strategies to break-down work](#) can be helpful to have at hand

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "Min Specs" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Use 'Min Specs' to help groups discover what is absolutely essential](#)
- Poster: [10 Powerful Strategies To Break Down Product Backlog Items](#)



Step 4: Narrow Down Even Further With "Impromptu Networking"

Now that we've created a list of "Min Specs", the team has performed the mental exercise of weeding out everything but the essentials. In this step, we're using [Impromptu Networking](#) to capitalize on the creative ideas and insights to simplify even further.

Invitation

"What creative solutions or outside-of-the-box ideas do you have for removing or simplifying items on our 'Min Specs' even further? Where can we re-use something that already exists?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to identify and write down a few ideas they have.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs to let them share their ideas and thoughts. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the most appealing ideas that emerged from the conversations. Adjust the 'Min Specs' as you go.

Our Findings

- If you do this online, you may want to double the timeboxes if you have the time. Or you can skip the part with the pairs if you're tight on time.



Step 5: Personal Next Steps

At the end of this workshop, your team probably has a pretty good idea of how to develop a walking skeleton. So now is a good time to end with personal next steps with the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#).

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the implementation of this walking skeleton? Where do you have the autonomy to act and/or the resources to do so?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **3 min** Collect the 15% Solutions on a shared workspace. Depending on how much time you have left, you can ask people to share some of their 15% Solutions.

Step 6: Closing

This workshop was essentially a form of exercise. But rather than building muscle, your team has invested in the skills and the creative thinking abilities it needs to simplify instead of complicate work. This is a vital skill for all Scrum teams, and individual developers, to learn. And like physical exercising, it can be hard and exhausting initially. But the more often you practice it, the easier it becomes.

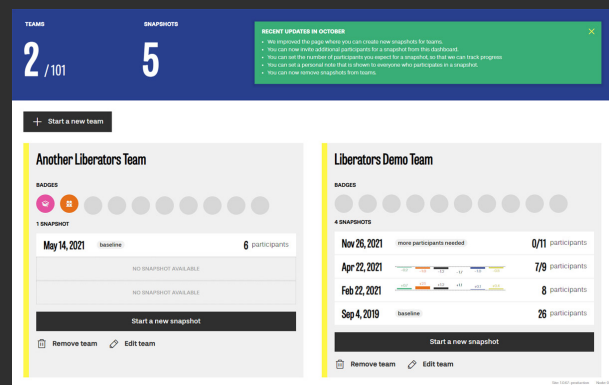
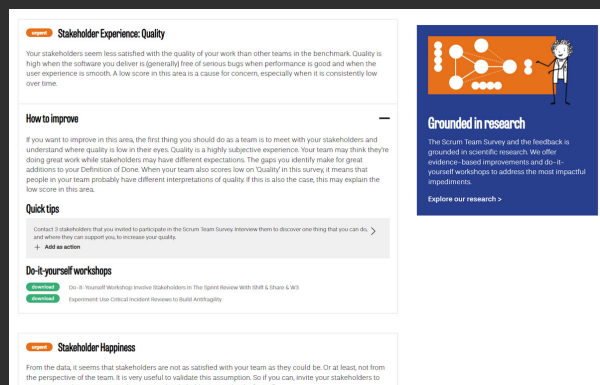
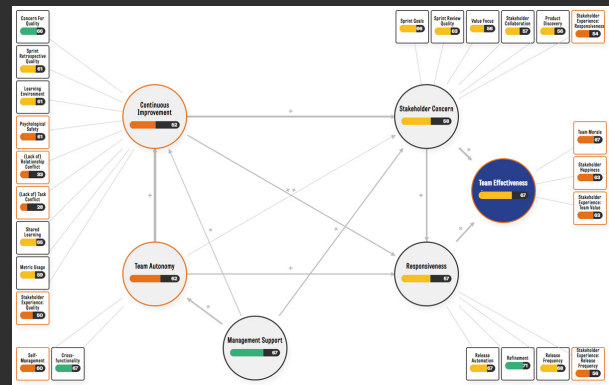
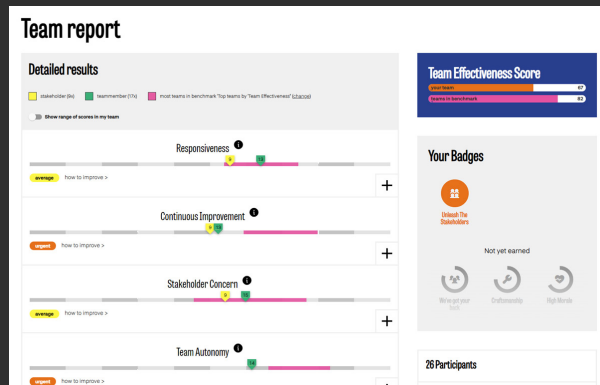
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

Supported by the community

We are super proud that The Liberators is almost entirely funded by the community. If you appreciate our work too, you can already support us for 12 dollars/year by becoming a [patron](#). In return, you gain free access to premium content, we share our work-in-progress and involve you in creating more awesome content.



Thank you for respecting our work!

We work hard to create high-quality content that puts you in a position to unleash your team. We're sure you appreciate that a lot of our time and money goes into this. At the same time, content like this is our main source of income. It's what pays our bills :)

If you purchased this content, we ask only that you treat our work with respect and don't share it with people outside your team. If you stumbled on it elsewhere without paying for it, and it offers you value, would you consider [supporting us too](#)? You can also check [out our other offerings](#).